



Fiery form: D. Gukesh secured eight wins on the top board and was the only player to cross a 3000 rating performance mark. MARK LIVSHITZ/FIDE

2700, while Arjun had been playing slightly lower-rated opponents in recent months. It made sense to keep them in their respective roles," said Srinath.

Serbia, undefeated at the time, posed little to no resistance in the fourth round. Gukesh, Arjun, and Vidit recorded comfortable wins, powering India to a commanding victory. The trend continued against Azerbaijan, where Praggnanandhaa and Vidit held their opponents to draws with dark pieces, while Gukesh and Arjun again delivered wins.

India then claimed a win over Hungary's A team to maintain its perfect record of 6/6, firmly establishing itself as the team to beat, but it was a job half done; the much stronger teams were waiting to prowl in the following rounds. Among them, in round six, was the 2018 gold medal winner China. After skipping the 2022 Olympiad, China was ready to take its top spot from Uzbekistan, but it had to overcome a surging Indian challenge first.

India's plan was simple: hold China to a draw and advance without taking a heavy blow. Coach Srinath crafted a bold yet risky game plan to execute this — he substituted Vidit with the experienced Harikrishna on board four, tasking him with neutralising the in-form Wang Yue.

Meanwhile, China made a

surprising move by benching reigning World Champion Ding Liren, denying fans the much-anticipated clash with Gukesh. The two will meet each other in the FIDE World Chess Championship final later this year. But here, Gukesh was pitted against an even tougher opponent, Wei Yi, who was having an extraordinary year.

Praggnanandhaa, Arjun, and Harikrishna obliged, playing solid, defensive games to secure draws, bringing the score to 1.5-1.5 with only the top board still in play.

Srinath knew Gukesh was a tough nut to crack, but now it was Wei's turn to experience it. He managed to hold the game on an equal footing for five hours, with Gukesh pressing hard with his pair of knights against his lone rook.